If Tuesday has always been yellow-green and you assumed everyone knew that, this one's for you. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Synaesthesia is an automatic crossing of the senses — letters and numbers having colours, sounds having shapes, days of the week having positions in space, words having tastes. It's consistent over a lifetime, involuntary, and present in perhaps four percent of people. It isn't imagination and it isn't a symptom of anything.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Assuming until adulthood that everyone's alphabet was coloured.
- Someone spelling a name wrong and it looking the wrong colour.
- Music arriving with texture and shape as well as sound.
- Being certain about associations you can't possibly justify.
- Finding the whole thing pleasant, mostly — this one's rarely a burden.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"You're imagining it."	It's involuntary and remarkably consistent — testable across decades.
"It's drug related."	Congenital synaesthesia has been there since childhood.
"Everyone associates things."	Learned association is different from automatic perception.
"It must be distracting."	Most synaesthetes wouldn't give it up. It often aids memory.
"It's a disorder."	It's a perceptual variation, and generally a rather nice one.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Unusually strong memory — the extra channel helps.

Creative and artistic advantages.

Rich, textured experience of ordinary things.

Often excellent with names, dates and sequences.

A genuinely unusual perspective on how minds can work.

What actually helps

- ☐ Take it seriously when they describe it
- ☐ Ask what it's actually like
- ☐ Don't tell them they're wrong about it
- ☐ Don't test them like a party trick
- ☐ Accept their associations are fixed
- ☐ Enjoy it with them

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

“What colour is my name?” *asked once, kindly*

“That sounds lovely.”

“How does that work?”

LESS HELPFUL

“Prove it.”

“That's not a real thing.”

“Do it again for my friend.”

Extra channels, permanently on. Mostly a good deal.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk